

Wizard of Oz Prototype

Fake the back-end to test the front-end experience

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

In a Wizard of Oz prototype, users interact with what looks like an automated system while a human secretly performs the back-end functions. It tests desirability and the experience of a capability before that capability is actually built.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Named after the 1900 story's 'man behind the curtain'; established in HCI research in the 1980s (Kelley, 1983).

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Some experiences (AI assistants, recommendation engines) are expensive to build. Faking the back-end lets teams test whether users even want the experience before investing.

HOW IT IS USED

Design a realistic front-end, have a hidden operator generate the responses in real time, and observe how users react as if the system were real.

WHEN IT IS USED

Prototyping capabilities that are costly or slow to build, especially interactive or 'intelligent' features.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

UX researchers, product teams and AI/service designers.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

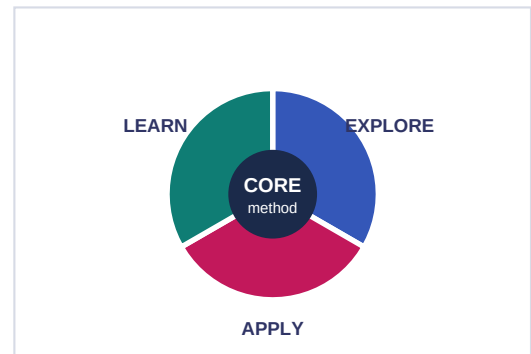


Figure 1. Wizard of Oz Prototype framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It decouples **desirability testing** from **feasibility**, letting teams validate demand before committing engineering effort.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Paper / Low-fi Prototype *Slibrary 8*

Solution Interview *Slibrary 9*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Kelley, J.F. (1984) 'An iterative design methodology for user-friendly natural language office information applications', *ACM ToIS*, 2(1), pp. 26–41.
 Buxton, B. (2007) *Sketching User Experiences*. San Francisco: Morgan Kaufmann.